

ly-used media players. However, before we get on to RealPlayer Alternative, let's take a look at the reason for the alternative: RealPlayer itself. This lumbering bulk of a player, once the preferred media player for many users, has taken a beating of late at the hands of users. The reason is simple - too many ads, and the sheer bulk of the player. Real Alternative, a free application from KL Software, allows you to play Real Media and other multimedia files without having to install RealPlayer or RealOne Player from Real Networks.

The size means a quick load on even slow machines (we ran it on a P III). This sleek and simple ad-free application is designed to play most media content, including the RealAudio (.ra and .rpm), RealMedia (.rm, .ram, .rmvb, .rpx, .smi and .smil), RealText (.rt), and ReadPix (.rp) formats, as well as non-Real media content such as MP3, MPEG, .avi, QuickTime movies, and CD/DVD content. It also supports RealMedia content embedded in Web pages. However, RealMedia .smi and .smil files are not fully supported. Real Alternative uses Media Player Classic as the default player, just like Quick Time Alternative does. This nifty, bare-bones player makes the application even more appealing.

The application requires the latest version of DirectX - 9.0c - to be present before installation can proceed. Even when loaded with files one after the other the player does not pause for breath, playing each file smoothly. Considering the application is free, Real Alternative offers an impressive array of options and functions.

4.2.4 Media Player Classic 6.4.8.4

Media Player Classic is an extremely lightweight media player for Windows. It looks just like the good old Media Player 6.4; however, this player is a wolf in sheep's clothing - well, in a sense, if you think wolves are cool. It comes loaded with features that would put any of the biggies to shame. Media Player Classic was created under the GPL and is currently maintained by a programmer who goes by the name Gabest. Originally developed as a closed source player, Media Player Classic is now an open source application.